

hard, but the consequences should be considered fully first. The migration system is about the state of the table structures, not the contents of the tables. Removing a field in your model results in a column getting removed from the database. All data in that column goes away. There is no “undo.” Unless you’ve made a backup of the database, the data is gone. Moving content is equivalent to adding a new column and deleting the old one, so it has all the challenges of deletion with added steps.

Changing your mind about the structure of your models can be problematic. In the `Promoter` model (and in others) you used a very Western-centric view of people’s names. The assumption that everyone has a first and last name is wrong. Patrick McKenzie has written a great article on this topic, called “Falsehoods Programmers Believe About Names” (<http://mng.bz/5o28>). Add it to your reading list, as it is valuable information.

Falsehood programmers believe

Articles similar to Patrick’s have become a genre unto themselves. There seems to be a lot of falsehoods we programmers believe. The following are a couple more that are seminal for your reading list:

- “Falsehoods Programmers Believe About Time” (<http://mng.bz/6n2p>)
- “Falsehoods Programmers Believe About Email” (<http://mng.bz/orEy>)
- “Falsehoods Programmers Believe About Geography” (<http://mng.bz/n18V>)

There are curated lists of these kinds of articles as well, Kevin Deldycke’s “awesome falsehood” (<http://mng.bz/vP5m>) has a decent round-up.

A better way to store names than using a first and last name field is to store a full name and the name the person wishes to be called (the common name). This doesn’t solve all the problems that Patrick enumerates, but it is a step in the right direction. To change the `Promoter` model to use this style, you have a problem: you already have data. Adding two new fields isn’t a big deal, but what do you do about the existing first and last names?

Since the existing structure uses Western-centric assumptions, let’s continue with the assumption that composing the first and last name together can constitute our full name, and the first name can be the common name. This doesn’t fix any problems with the existing data’s assumptions, but it does create a space from which you can move forwards. By transferring the first and last name data into full name and common name fields, you can then remove the first and last name fields, leaving your model in a better state.

This transformation is done in three steps:

- 1 Add the new full name and common name fields.
- 2 Construct the data for the full and common name fields based on the existing first and last names.
- 3 Remove the existing first and last names.